

SUSHI
NAKAZAWA



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Chum Salmon
さけ

Aburi Masunosuke 「King salmon」
炙り鱒の介

Hokkaido no Hotate
北海道の帆立

Aori ika to Umeboshi to Kinome
煽り烏賊と梅ぶしと木の芽

Zuwaigani oshizushi to Kani-Miso
ズワイガニ押し寿司と蟹味噌

Hirame
平目

Kinmedai
金目鯛

Sawara
鯖

Aji
鯯

Shima Aji
鯧鯨

Kanpachi
間八

Koshinaga Maguro
コシナガマグロ

Akami | Chūtoro | Ōtoro
赤身・中トロ・大トロ

Ikura
イクラ

Hokkaido Uni
北海道雲丹

Kinmedai II
金目鯛II

Anago
穴子

Tamagoyaki
卵焼き

SUSHI
NAKAZAWA



Nestled in the Greenwich Village, Sushi Nakazawa has long been acclaimed as one of the leading sushi places in New York City. Chef Daisuke Nakazawa is one of the best apprentices of the legendary sushi chef Jiro Ono, so his restaurant in New York immediately became very popular upon opening. While many restaurants are crazily raising their prices, especially after the pandemic, Sushi Nakazawa is sticking with its \$150 price for weekday omakase. It is affordable for many people, and the fact that diners will be served with more than twenty pieces of nigiri makes the omakase menu worthy. Nevertheless, New York is a place where people are seeking the ultimate luxuriousness. With the emerging of finer and finer sushi places like Uchū, Sushi Noz, and the newly opened Yoshino, is it still a wise choice to keep the price low and to serve average quality sushi?

Diners in New York City nowadays are willing to pay over a half thousand dollars for a luxury sushi dining experience, and places like Sushi Noz or Masa are still highly in-demand even after they raised their price (Sushi Noz from \$300 to \$395 and Masa from \$595 to \$800). Meanwhile, there are newly emerged cheaper and more casual omakase dining places like Shiki where diners only pay \$65 for a sushi omakase dining experience. Sushi Nakazawa is now at a very awkward status that many serious sushi connoisseurs will avoid. It is neither proper for an authentic sushi omakase experience nor ideal for a casual meal. Twenty pieces of nigiri for only \$150 is a good deal, but the quality of each piece is vital. If none of the twenty pieces is impressive, then it may be better to just have eight pieces of high-quality nigiri for this price.



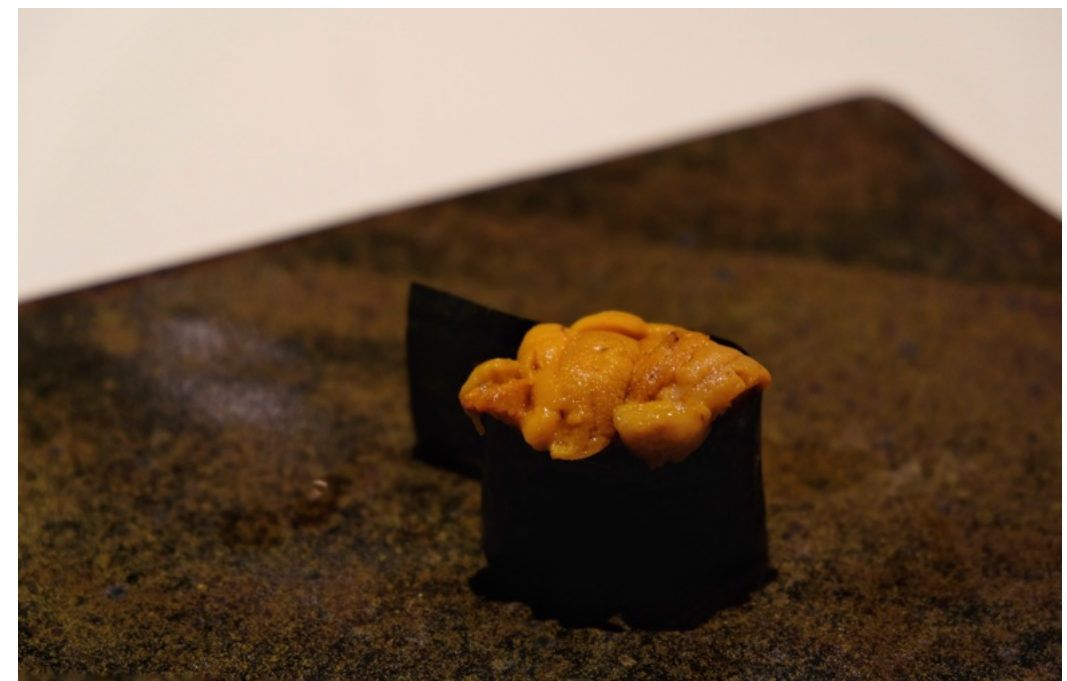


Sushi Nakazawa evokes a sense of very elegant yet low-profile luxuriousness.

The interior design using contemporary black-white elements with the additional decoration of bright flowers makes it a casual and tradition-breaking sushi place that implies an atmosphere of ingratiating itself into the American aesthetics. I decide to check out this place due to its fame, and I am also wondering where it can reach for this price.

For lunch omakase at Sushi Nakazawa, only one female chef is present, and she seems to be very busy handling all the works by herself. The lunch journey unfolds as soon as I ordered my sencha. Two pieces of salmon are served right away. The chum salmon contains less fat thus the taste is more on the refreshing side. It is indeed a good starter. The king salmon from New Zealand tastes completely different, not only due to its richer unctuousness but also its tenderness and umami.

The two pieces of salmon could be regarded as a prelude to the omakase, as salmon is something forbidden in the strict traditional sushi omakase menu. The following three pieces of Crustacean and Mollusca seafood nigiri are the exposition. The scallop from Hokkaido showcases gorgeous umami, and the aori ika introduces a similar yet altered creaminess. The addition of umeboshi sauce and kinome has the benefit of providing essential acidity and refreshing scents. However, the umeboshi also introduces too much sweetness that may seem unnecessary as the aori ika per se contains a perfectly-balanced sweetness. The Zuwaigani oshizushi with kani-miso is a disaster. The Zuwaigani is unfortunately dry. It is also too thin that I could barely taste any flavor of the Zuwaigani. The following two pieces of Shiromi (White-fleshed fish) nigiri are disappointing due to the quality of the fish.





Following the Shiromi are four pieces of nigiri of Hikarimono. Hikarimono refers to fishes that have stronger umami on their own. Sawara not only has a strong fishy odor but also has fairly dry flesh. Comparatively, aji and shima aji are much better as both of them have sophisticated umami. Kanpachi is the last piece for Hikarimono, and it is well prepared but not necessarily memorable.

Before the classic trio of tuna, I am served with the rarely-seen low-class Koshinaga Maguro nigiri. In spite of the fact that it is also a type of tuna, it has a completely different taste than the Atlantic bluefin tuna that we usually eat at a sushi place. Then the trio of bluefin tuna is served, but rather unprofessional for a fine-dining sushi place. Three pieces of Akami, Chutoro, and Otoro are served at the same time, resulting in an unevenness among temperatures of each piece.

Just as expected, ikura and Hokkaido sea urchin are presented after the trio. The ikura is one of the best pieces of sushi of today, and the uni is also not bad. Before ending my lunch omakase, I added one piece of kinmedai. After that, the classical coda comes. Anago is one of the best pieces of sushi, along with the ikura one. The tamagoyaki is, however, not as impressive as expected. Mr. Nakazawa is known for his decade of tamago-making training, but I taste nothing special here. Unlike traditional omakase in Japan, sushi places overseas usually add a dessert course following the western cuisine tradition. Here at Sushi Nakazawa, a creme brûlée is served at the end. Unfortunately, the egg custard part has nothing to do with smoothness. Moreover, the creme brûlée is also too sweet. I would rather end my lunch with just the tamago.

